

difficulty level column. This gives the total mark for the piece, out of a maximum of 60 marks.

For this A Level Music qualification, pieces identified as level 7 are identified as 'standard'; above this (level 8 and above) pieces are 'more difficult' and below this (levels 1-6) they are 'less difficult'. For students selecting pieces of music that are levels 1-6, they should be advised that to do so may be self-penalising as they may restrict their opportunity to access the higher levels and marks in the assessment grids for their performances.

Where instruments other than those listed in the *Pearson Edexcel GCSE, AS and A level Music Difficulty Levels Booklet* are presented, the difficulty level will be assessed at a comparable level of demand, including performances where there is no tradition of graded examinations for the instrument presented. For example:

Beatboxing: To achieve Standard level the music must be fast, include much syncopation, make consistent use of effects such as echo or reverb, and include a wide range of imaginative sounds, including mimicry of standard instruments and scratching effects. Submissions not matching this description are assessed as Less Difficult. More Difficult submissions will add the impression of contrapuntal or melody/accompaniment effects, a variety of styles and textures and some singing and/or humming along with the beats.

Rapping: To achieve Standard level the music will be consistently fast paced, requiring control of articulation, make much use of syncopation and have a sung hook. Submissions not matching this description are assessed as Less Difficult. More Difficult submissions will incorporate elements of vocal percussion and beatboxing, and will demand complex breathing and articulation techniques.

Ensemble performance: In all cases the Difficulty Level for ensemble performance must be decided by directly comparing the student's part with the examples for solo performance provided and looking for an equivalent level.

When performing a live solo line over a pre-recorded/sequenced backing track, the level of difficulty is assessed on the live part performed only.

Raw mark	Less Difficult	Standard	More Difficult
1	1	1	2
2	2	3	3
3	3	4	5
4	4	5	6
5	5	6	8
6	6	8	9
7	7	9	11
8	8	10	12
9	9	11	14
10	10	13	15
11	11	14	17
12	12	15	18
13	13	16	20
14	14	18	21
15	15	19	23
16	16	20	24
17	17	21	26
18	18	23	27
19	19	24	29
20	20	25	30
21	21	26	32
22	22	28	33
23	23	29	35
24	24	30	36

Raw mark	Less Difficult	Standard	More Difficult
28	28	35	42
29	29	36	44
30	30	38	45
31	31	39	47
32	32	40	48
33	33	41	50
34	34	43	51
35	35	44	53
36	36	45	54
37	37	46	56
38	38	48	57
39	39	49	59
40	40	50	60
41	41	51	60
42	42	53	60
43	43	54	60
44	44	55	60
45	45	56	60
46	46	58	60
47	47	59	60
48	48	60	60

Security and backups

It is the centre's responsibility to keep the work that students have submitted for assessment secure.

Secure storage is defined as a securely-locked cabinet or cupboard.

For materials stored electronically, centres are strongly advised to utilise firewall protection and virus-checking software, and to employ an effective backup strategy, so that an up-to-date archive of students' evidence is maintained.

Further information

For up-to-date advice on teacher involvement and administration of non-examination assessments, please refer to the Joint Council for Qualifications (JCQ) document *Instructions for conducting non-examination assessments (new GCE and GCSE specifications)* available on the JCQ website: www.jcq.org.uk

Component 2: Composing

Overview

The purpose of this component is to assess students' skills in composing music. It allows students to appreciate the process of creating music. Students will learn more of the processes involved in creating music through developing the technical and expressive skills needed by a composer.

Composing music is the creative process by which most of the music we experience came into being. Students will be encouraged to explore a range of compositional starting points, investigate a range of techniques for developing and manipulating ideas. They will then turn their ideas into completed pieces of music.

Students can also explore the skills needed to compose for different musical forces.

Students must submit two compositions, of a combined duration of at least six minutes:

- one composition (Free choice composition) can be chosen from six briefs relating to areas of study, or free composition, carrying 40 of the marks for the composing assessment. This composition must be at least four minutes in duration.
- one composition must be from a list of four briefs assessing technique, carrying 20 of the marks for the composing assessment. This composition must be at least one minute in duration.

Free choice composition (40 marks)	Briefs assessing technique (20 marks)
Briefs relating to areas of study 1. Vocal Music 2. Instrumental Music 3. Music for Film 4. Popular Music and Jazz 5. Fusion 6. New Directions OR Free composition	Briefs assessing technique 1. Bach chorale 2. Two-part counterpoint 3. Arrangement 4. Remix

Content

Skills, knowledge and understanding

Students will be required to demonstrate the ability to:

- make use of musical elements, techniques and resources to create and develop musical ideas with technical control and expressive understanding, either freely as the composer chooses, or by responding to a brief or commission supplied by others
- compose music that develops musical ideas and shows understanding of musical devices and conventions in relation to the chosen genre, style and tradition
- compose music that is musically convincing and shows a sophisticated use of musical elements in combination
- compose music that makes creative use of musical ideas and shows understanding of musical devices and conventions in relation to the chosen genre, style and tradition.

Students will also be required to apply, practically, knowledge and understanding of:

- specialist musical vocabulary and notation appropriate to the context
- the relationship between compositional devices and techniques, musical elements, including harmonic progressions, tonal relationships and musical structures appropriate to the context.

In order to compose in a particular style or genre, it is useful to study examples of that style.

Students should be given a wide range of opportunities to develop their composition skills. These could include:

- writing for instruments and/or voices and/or Digital Audio Workstation (DAW): idiomatic and expressive handling of appropriate timbres and textures
- creating and developing musical ideas within chosen forms and structures and an understanding of the principles of harmonic, melodic and rhythmic construction appropriate to the composition undertaken
- working to a set brief: developing the necessary technical skills to meet the requirements of a brief and relating it to its intended audience and occasion
- acquiring a harmonic and tonal vocabulary appropriate to the composition undertaken.

Students need knowledge of the different ways of notating compositions scores, for example:

- staff notation
- graphic notation
- written accounts.

Students should practice composing to a specific brief and within a specified time limit. They may work in any style, subject to the brief.

In order to compose in a particular style or genre, it is useful to study examples of that style or genre in some detail. This will enable students to recognise and use appropriate musical vocabulary relevant to their compositions. Much listening and appraising work will involve analysis of the set works, these could sometimes be used as models for composing.

Students may compose their pieces of music using music technology.

Composition using a Digital Audio Workstation: students should study how digital processing can expand the sonic palette using sampling, synthesis, EQ, compression and effects processing such as reverb, delay, flange, distortion, etc. They should learn how to integrate samples and synthesised sounds with acoustic and electronic instruments. Students will demonstrate that they can create a mood or communicate a message or meaning in their music.

Musical elements

Depending on the choice of instrument(s) and/or voice(s), and the piece of music composed, the student should use the appropriate musical elements in their composition.

The musical elements are listed below:

- Organisation of pitch
- Tonality
- Structure
- Sonority
- Texture
- Tempo, metre and rhythm
- Dynamics (use of dynamics).

Musical contexts

Students should take into account the effect of the purpose and intention of their piece of music, and the effect of audience, time and place when performing their pieces. Students should compose their music as appropriate to its style and mood. Students should take into account how music is created, developed and performed in different historical, social and cultural contexts, as well as how music from different historical, social and cultural contexts has changed over time.

Musical language

Depending on the choice of instrument(s) and/or voice(s), and the piece of music, the student should be able to compose music using the appropriate musical language.

The musical language includes the following:

- reading and writing of staff notation, including rhythmic notation in compound time and all key signatures
- chords and associated chord symbols, standard harmonic progressions, for example chord inversions, dominant 7th chords and extended chords, for example secondary 7ths and 9ths
- musical vocabulary and terminology related to the areas of study including recognition and use of appropriate musical vocabulary and terminology, for example glissando, repetition and conjunct and use of sophisticated terminology, for example portamento, and ascending minor scale.

Compositional briefs

New compositional briefs will be released each year.

The briefs will:

- be released on 1 September at the beginning of the year of certification (Free choice composition)
- be released on 1 April in the year of certification (Briefs assessing technique)
- be released via the Pearson website
- contain details of audience or occasion within the brief.

The format of the briefs will always be the same each year but the specific content will vary.

- One composition (Free choice composition) can be chosen from six briefs relating to areas of study, or free composition, carrying 40 of the marks for the composing assessment. This composition must be at least four minutes in duration.
- One composition must be from a list of four briefs assessing technique, carrying 20 of the marks for the composing assessment. This composition must be at least one minute in duration.
- The two compositions combined must be a minimum of six minutes in duration, regardless of the combination of compositions chosen.

The compositional briefs will make compositional demands in terms of the treatment of ideas, techniques and structures but between them will be sufficiently open-ended to allow students the freedom to work in any style or genre, or for any instrument.

Briefs relating to areas of study

The format of these briefs will be the same each year but the specific content will vary. Each brief will relate to an audience and/or occasion, and students will then compose in a chosen style from one of the areas of study.

Compositions to these briefs must be a minimum of four minutes in length.

Students should ensure that their composition to a brief relating to areas of study is of sufficient length to meet the minimum overall composition length, given the requirements of their chosen brief assessing technique.

Vocal Music

Students should investigate the relationship between the structure of vocal pieces and the structure of texts by studying a variety of song forms (for example da capo, strophic, verse/chorus) and word settings. They should investigate the handling of instrumental accompaniments and/or backings.

They may work in any style, subject to the brief.

Instrumental Music

Students should investigate the characteristics of instruments, instrumental ensembles and instrumental forms associated with music from the period (for example dance suite, sonata, string quartet). They should practice developing musical structures, relating these to the brief and working to sustain a piece with a varied and creative musical outcome.

They may work in any style, subject to the brief.

Music for Film

Students should study the techniques of underscoring moving images to produce a satisfying and flowing succession of musical moods and atmospheres. They should learn how to enhance visual or dramatic action in which the narrative and sequencing may not follow conventional forms and structures.

They will not be required to follow exact timings, nor to synchronise with film and/or video clips.

Fusions

Students should learn how harmony, melody, rhythm and instrumentation combine to create a characteristic stylistic 'feel' in the music.

They should investigate examples of world music, for example the music of the Latin Americas and the traditional music of the British Isles, and gain practice in the handling of the musical elements that characterise them in order to create pieces that demonstrate a fusion of styles and stylistic influences.

Popular Music and Jazz

Students should study the characteristics of instruments and instrumental combinations – acoustic, amplified and synthesised – that are associated with this area of study and the relationship between lead lines and backing textures. They should investigate common song structures and structural devices (for example verse/chorus, 32-bar, middle eight and head arrangements), and the role played by technology in the creation and production of popular music.

New directions

Students should study how traditional melody, harmony, rhythm and form broke down at the beginning of the twentieth century. Composers branched in new directions searching for their own musical language. Students should explore atonal music and new forms of harmony such as use of a tone row. They should explore new timbres through preparing instruments such as prepared piano or through electronic means.

Free composition

Students may produce one composition that is free, i.e. not related to a set brief. Free composition enables students to develop their own ideas outside of a set brief.

Students are free to draw inspiration or starting points from set works and briefs from previous years as well as exploring their own interests and the music from the world around them.

The piece composed by the students may be for any instrument or voice, or combination of instruments and/or voices, and in any style.

Compositions to these briefs must be a minimum of four minutes in length.

Students should ensure that their free composition is of sufficient length to meet the minimum overall composition length, given the requirements of their chosen brief assessing technique.

Briefs assessing technique

One composition must be to a brief assessing technique. Four briefs will be published each year. Compositions in response to these briefs must be completed under controlled conditions, with a guided maximum allowed time of 6 hours.

These briefs give students sufficient material to enable them to compose in the styles described below. They will give students opportunities to create music by employing and developing specific compositional techniques.

Each exercise will consist of a stimulus which will form the basis of the study.

The nature of these briefs means that the length of the compositions will vary, although the shortest will be a minimum of one minute in length. This should be considered when choosing compositions, as the minimum composition length of six minutes across both compositions must be observed.

Brief 1 – Bach chorale

Students must learn how to harmonise two chorales in the manner of J.S. Bach by adding alto, tenor and bass parts to a given soprano.

Using an appropriate harmonic vocabulary students need to be familiar with triads in root position and first inversion, the tonic triad in second inversion in contexts where Bach would have used it, seventh chords and their inversions typical of Bach's style. They must also learn about voice-leading and other procedures typical of Bach's style including modulation to closely-related keys, passing notes and suspensions.

The given chorales will be between 12 and 18 bars in length each. Modal chorales, and chorales in $\frac{3}{4}$ time will not be set.

Brief 2 – Two-part counterpoint

Students must also learn how to complete a two-part baroque texture for bass and violin or flute using an appropriate harmonic vocabulary.

They must be able to construct rhythmically satisfying and stylish melodic lines in treble and bass and to follow 18th century conventions with regard to texture, voice leading and structure.

The stimulus will be between 24 and 42 bars in length and students will be required to complete passages in both treble and bass. They will not be required to add, or work to, a figured bass.

In each of these studies students should be aware of the context in terms of audience and occasion in which they would originally have appeared. For example, the chorale was intended to be sung by a congregation during the performance of a longer work, and the two-part exercise, drawn from a baroque dance suite would have been intended for social occasions.

Brief 3 – Arrangement

Students should learn how to harmonise a given melody and extend this to form a satisfying arrangement for instruments and/or voices.

They should study the techniques of writing for different instrumental and/or vocal combinations and of extending and varying melodic material to sustain a coherently structured piece.

The given melody will be between 12 and 24 bars in length and the number of instrumental/vocal parts that are specified in the brief will be no more than four. The brief will specify an audience and occasion.

Brief 4 – Remix

Students should learn how to develop a given audio sample into a remix suitable for performance in a nightclub setting. They should investigate the stylistic characteristics and conventions of electronic dance music. They should learn how to edit and manipulate samples, timbres and textures and to extend these into a coherent structure by developing the elements of rhythm, melody, harmony and sound manipulation.

The stimulus will be provided as a .wav file. The clarity, mixing and stereo imaging of the final recording will form part of the assessment.

A stereo recording of your remix must be submitted in the following format:

- wav
- sample rate: 44.1kHz
- bit depth: 16-bit.

Assessment information

Task setting

- Free choice composition briefs will be released on 1 September at the beginning of the year of certification. Free compositions have no brief and may be started at any time.
- Briefs assessing technique will be released on 1 April in the year of certification.

Students must compose two pieces, one drawn from each of the following columns:

Free choice composition (40 marks)	Briefs assessing technique (20 marks)
Briefs relating to areas of study 1. Vocal Music 2. Instrumental Music 3. Music for Film 4. Popular Music and Jazz 5. Fusion 6. New Directions OR Free composition	Briefs assessing technique 1. Bach chorale 2. Two-part counterpoint 3. Arrangement 4. Remix

Students should choose the composition brief from those released by Pearson and decide their free composition with the support of their teacher.

Free compositions should be worked on and recorded in the student's intended year of certification.

The overall length of the submission, i.e. both pieces, must total a minimum of six minutes. However, if a student wishes to compose for longer than six minutes to demonstrate their compositional skills more fully, they may do so. The compositions should be of sufficient length and complexity to give the composer adequate opportunity to showcase their abilities.

Group compositions are not acceptable for which the music is the work of more than one student.

The free choice composition must be at least four minutes in duration. The briefs assessing technique composition must be at least one minute in duration. The two compositions combined must be a minimum of six minutes in duration.

Students must ensure that the length of the free choice composition complements the chosen brief assessing technique, and that their composition choices enable the minimum total duration to be achieved. The Sample Assessment Materials for this qualification contain examples of the types of briefs assessing technique that will be released on 1 April each year.

The maximum guided length of compositions is eight minutes. Submissions over the guided maximum time for combined compositions will still be marked. This is guidance for teachers to avoid students submitting excessively long submissions which may be self-penalising.

Task taking

- The assessment may take place over multiple sessions.
- Compositions must be submitted at the end of the course.
- Centres must ensure that compositions submitted are valid for the series in which they are submitted.

Both compositions must have a combined minimum duration of six minutes.

Gaps between pieces and tuning **do not** count towards the composition time.

Free choice composition

Controlled conditions

The student must spend at least 2 hours on the development of the composition, plus the final write-up and the recording of their composition, in the centre under the teacher's supervision.

Teachers must monitor and authenticate preparatory work throughout the preparatory period and prior to commencement of the composition period to ensure it is the student's own unaided, personal and independent work.

Teacher guidance during this period must be restricted to: the availability and suitability of sources and materials, the prevention of plagiarism and ensuring the work is conducted in accordance with specification requirements and procedures.

Feedback

Teachers may help students to understand rubrics, assessment criteria and controls. Teachers must not provide students with solutions. Any additional feedback must be recorded on the Composing Authentication Sheet, please see *Appendix 2*.

Collaboration

Students may work together on their research, but group compositions are not allowed.

While research may be carried out by the student in or out of the centre, the final composition and score or commentary must be completed in the centre under teacher supervision.

Resources

Students must have equal access to IT resources. Students should have access to a range of resources/interpretations/texts to enable them to make choices as required for their tasks.

Composition recording

Recording the compositions

Compositions and arrangements may be realised through conventional instruments or music technology. The quality of the recording of the performance will not be assessed. Only the actual composition itself will be assessed.

The student does not have to perform the piece of music they have composed (with the exception of sequenced parts of a composition using music technology).

Authenticity

The final recording and write-up of the score or written account must be completed in the centre under teacher supervision.

If students wish to re-record a composition before submission, they must re-record the whole composition, and not just part of it.

Items for submission for assessment

1. Score/lead sheet/written account of the composition

A detailed notated score appropriate to the style of music submitted. It can be submitted on manuscript paper or as a printout. 'Score' refers to any of the following: a full score in conventional staff notation, a lead sheet or chord chart, track sheets, tables or diagrams, a screenshot from the music production software, or written account of the composition.

The purpose of the score is to justify the intentions of the piece of music that has been composed, so that it may be easily replicated by another performer.

The score may be handwritten or printed. Students must submit their work in a format appropriate to the style. This may be staff notation, lead sheet or chord chart, annotated screenshots, annotated track diagrams or tablature or graphic scores.

Students not enclosing a score must submit a written account of the composition instead (no more than 500 words). This piece of writing should give a detailed description of the composition (or arrangement) and its purpose and meaning. It should refer to the musical content throughout.

Written accounts must contain similar information to that found in a score: details of performance indications and the composer's intentions. A good account containing sufficient information for an acceptable realisation of the composer's intentions is acceptable for any style of music.

Whichever format or combination of formats is chosen, the presentation must be sufficiently clear and detailed enough for the assessor to be able to assess the composition or arrangement.

For music technology briefs, no score should be submitted. A recording should be submitted in the following format:

- wav
- sample rate: 44.1kHz
- bit depth: 16-bit.

The presentation of the score or written account is not assessed but students are reminded of the importance of clear and orderly presentation.

2. Recording

A complete recording of both pieces must be submitted via the online submission platform LWT. Each composition for each student should be a separate track, individually labelled with their centre number, candidate number and composition title. The recording can be made live or be studio-produced.

3. Composing Authentication Sheet

The Composing Authentication Sheet (CAS) must be completed by the teacher, and signed by the student and teacher, authenticating that the work is the student's own. Please see *Appendix 2*.

4. Submissions not meeting minimum time requirement

The combined composition time of both compositions must be at least six minutes.

Students submitting combined compositions of less than six minutes in length will be marked against the assessment criteria on the following pages. The total composition mark will then be reduced proportionally according to how many seconds the combined composition time is less than six minutes. Please see *Appendix 10: Mark penalty tables for submissions not meeting the minimum assessment time*.

Gaps between pieces and tuning **do not** count towards the composition time.

Assessment criteria

Compositions will be externally assessed for all students. All assessment materials must be sent to the examiner to arrive by 15 May in the year of certification.

There are 60 marks available for this assessment. Of these, there are 40 marks available for free choice compositions.

Compositions will be assessed individually, using the relevant grids given below.

These criteria have been developed to assess students' skills in developing musical ideas, demonstrating technical control and demonstrating musical coherence.

Marks for each composition will be added together to give a total mark out of 60 for this component.

Free choice compositions (whether to a brief related to areas of study or free compositions) will be marked against 3 grids, each carrying 13–14 marks. These grids assess creating and developing musical ideas with coherence, creating and developing musical ideas with expressive control, and creating and developing musical ideas with technical control.

Composition assessment grid 1: Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Coherence

These marks are awarded for the design and management of musical structures, ideas and formal processes and the balance between unity and variety.

Level	Mark	Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Coherence (AO2)
	0	No rewardable material
Level 1	1–2	- There is an attempt to develop and extend musical ideas but there are some obtrusive misjudgments that compromise the effectiveness of the piece. - There is an attempt at basic, balanced structures but perhaps repetitive, predictable or showing too great a diversity of ideas.
Level 2	3–5	- Musical ideas are developed and extended but there are some obvious misjudgments and a lack of direction in parts. - There is an attempt at basic, balanced structures but the piece lacks fluency and variety.
Level 3	6–8	- Musical ideas are developed and extended in parts and any misjudgements do not detract from the overall effectiveness of the piece. - The piece demonstrates a satisfactory use of basic structures; these may be formulaic or standard forms with an attempt at some extension and development. Fluency and contrast will be maintained for the most part.
Level 4	9–11	- Musical ideas are developed and extended effectively for most of the piece. - Musical elements and ideas all contribute to some sense of wholeness with some sense of fluency, and a balance of unity and variety that is convincingly maintained.
Level 5	12–13	- Musical ideas are created, developed and extended with assurance and imagination throughout. - Musical elements and ideas all contribute to a sense of wholeness with a sophisticated sense of fluency, and a mature balance of unity and variety throughout.

Composition assessment grid 2: Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Expressive Control

These marks are awarded for the expressive control of the music elements, the pacing and management of moods and atmosphere, effects and dramatic flow, appropriate to the chosen style and/or genre.

Marks are also awarded for the response to the brief or, in a free composition, the realisation of the intentions of the piece, and the effectiveness with which it meets its intended purpose and/or audience.

Level	Mark	Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Expressive Control (AO2)
	0	No rewardable material
Level 1	1–2	• An attempt to respond to the brief but with limited sense of audience and occasion. • There are attempts at creating moods, atmosphere and/or effects, but these are compromised by obtrusive misjudgments or are inconsistently handled. • For brief-set composition only: A response to the brief with limited sense of audience and occasion.
Level 2	3–5	• A response to the brief that lacks sophistication and/or detail. • The musical elements are used to create some a few contrasted and well-paced moods, atmosphere and effects but there are some obvious misjudgements. • For brief-set composition only: A serious response to the brief with an attempt to meet audience and occasion.
Level 3	6–8	• A creative response to the brief with some sense of audience and occasion. • The musical elements are used to create some contrasted and well-paced moods, atmosphere and effects that are communicated successfully in parts. • For brief-set composition only: A creative response to the brief with some sense of audience and occasion.

Level	Mark	Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Expressive Control (AO2)
Level 4	9–11	• An ambitious and creative response to the brief. • The musical elements are used to create contrasted and well-paced moods, atmosphere and effects that are communicated successfully for most of the piece. • For brief-set composition only: An ambitious and creative response to the brief with a sense of audience and occasion.
Level 5	12–14	• The musical elements are used with maturity and confidence to create contrasted and well-paced moods, atmosphere and effects that are communicated successfully throughout. • For brief-set composition only: A mature and sophisticated response to the brief with a well developed sense of audience and occasion.

Composition assessment grid 3: Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Technical Control

These marks are awarded for the control of musical elements and of devices and conventions appropriate to the chosen style and/or genre.

Level	Mark	Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Technical Control (AO2)
	0	No rewardable material
Level 1	1–2	• There are attempts to control musical elements, and to manage appropriate stylistic devices and conventions for the chosen genre/style, but these are unconvincing for the most part. • Misjudgments compromise the success of the piece. • There are some significant unplayable/unsingable passages and/or the handling is unidiomatic. Textures are largely unvaried.
Level 2	3–5	• The control of elements and stylistic devices and conventions for the chosen genre/style are secure in some of the piece, but there are some obvious misjudgements and/or inconsistencies. • Forces and textures are inconsistently handled with some obvious misjudgements.
Level 3	6–8	• The control of elements and the control of stylistic devices and conventions for the chosen genre/style are generally secure and any misjudgements do not detract from the overall effectiveness of the piece. • Forces and textures are handled without serious misjudgement although they lack variety and/or development in parts.
Level 4	9–11	• The control of elements is secure for most of the piece. Any misjudgments are minor. • Stylistic devices and conventions for the chosen genre/style have been selected appropriately and handled convincingly, but with one or two minor misjudgments. • The forces and textures are handled idiomatically with some development and variety.
Level 5	12–13	• The control of musical elements is assured and sophisticated throughout. • Stylistic devices and conventions for the chosen genre/style have been selected appropriately and handled convincingly throughout. • Forces and textures are handled idiomatically and exploited and varied with creativity and authority.

Briefs assessing technique

Controlled conditions

The student must complete their composition under controlled conditions, within 4-6 hours. This time includes the development of the composition, the final write-up and the recording of their composition in the centre under the teacher's supervision.

Teacher guidance during this period must be restricted to: the availability and suitability of sources and materials, the prevention of plagiarism and ensuring the work is conducted in accordance with specification requirements and procedures.

Compositions can be completed over multiple sessions, but work must be collected and kept securely in the centre between sessions. Students must not have access to their work between sessions.

Feedback

Teachers may help students to understand rubrics, assessment criteria and controls. Teachers must not provide students with solutions. Any additional feedback must be recorded on the Composing Authentication Sheet, please see *Appendix 2*.

Collaboration

Students may work together on their research, but group compositions are not allowed.

While research may be carried out by the student in or out of the centre, the final composition and score or commentary must be completed in the centre under teacher supervision.

Resources

Students must have equal access to IT resources. Students should have access to a range of resources/interpretations/texts to enable them to make choices as required for their tasks.

Composition recording

Recording the compositions

Compositions and arrangements may be realised through conventional instruments or music technology. The quality of the recording of the performance will not be assessed. Only the actual composition itself will be assessed.

The student does not have to perform the piece of music they have composed (with the exception of sequenced parts of a composition using music technology).

Authenticity

Students and teachers must sign the Composing Authentication Sheet, please see *Appendix 2*. Teachers must be satisfied that the work is the student's own and should sign the Composing Authentication Sheet to this effect.

The final recording and write-up of the score or written account must be completed in the centre under teacher supervision.

If students wish to re-record a composition before submission, they must re-record the whole composition, and not just part of it.

Items for submission for assessment

1. Score/lead sheet/written account of the composition

A detailed notated score appropriate to the style of music submitted. It can be submitted on manuscript paper or as a printout. 'Score' refers to any of the following: a full score in conventional staff notation, a lead sheet or chord chart, track sheets, tables or diagrams, a screenshot from the music production software, or written account of the composition.

The purpose of the score is to justify the intentions of the piece of music that has been composed, so that it may be easily replicated by another performer.

The score may be handwritten or printed. Students must submit their work in a format appropriate to the style. This may be staff notation, lead sheet or chord chart, annotated screenshots, annotated track diagrams or tablature or graphic scores.

Students not enclosing a score must submit a written account of the composition instead (no more than 500 words). This piece of writing should give a detailed description of the composition (or arrangement) and its purpose and meaning. It should refer to the musical content throughout.

Written accounts must contain similar information to that found in a score: details of performance indications and the composer's intentions. A good account containing sufficient information for an acceptable realisation of the composer's intentions is acceptable for any style of music.

Whichever format or combination of formats is chosen, the presentation must be sufficiently clear and detailed enough for the assessor to be able to assess the composition or arrangement.

For music technology briefs, no score should be submitted. A recording should be submitted in the following format:

- wav
- sample rate: 44.1kHz
- bit depth: 16-bit.

The presentation of the score or written account is not assessed but students are reminded of the importance of clear and orderly presentation.

2. Recording

A complete recording of both pieces must be submitted via the online submission platform LWT. Each composition for each student should be a separate track, individually labelled with their centre number, candidate number and composition title. The recording can be made live or be studio-produced.

3. Composing Authentication Sheet

The Composing Authentication Sheet (CAS) must be completed by the teacher, and signed by the student and teacher, authenticating that the work is the student's own. Please see *Appendix 2*.

Assessment criteria

Compositions will be externally assessed for all students. All assessment materials must be sent to the examiner to arrive by 15 May in the year of certification.

There are 60 marks available for this assessment. Of these, there are 20 marks available for Briefs assessing technique compositions.

Compositions will be assessed individually, using the relevant grids given below.

These criteria have been developed to assess students' skills in developing musical ideas, demonstrating technical control and demonstrating musical coherence.

Marks for each composition will be added together to give a total mark out of 60 for this component.

Briefs assessing technique compositions will be marked against 4 grids, each carrying 5 marks. Grids 1-3 are common to all briefs assessing technique. These assess creating and developing musical ideas with coherence, creating and developing musical ideas with expressive control, and creating and developing musical ideas with technical control. Grid 4 assesses the students' response to the brief, and is specific to each type of brief assessing technique.

Composition assessment grid 1: Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Coherence

Marks are awarded for the organisation of the music: the melodic construction, harmony and rhythm.

Level	Mark	Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Coherence (AO2)
	0	No rewardable material
Level 1	1	- Little or no structuring and control of key and modulation. - Limited understanding and control of chords and chord progressions with many unconvincing moments. - Limited sense of melodic shape. Melodies lack direction and structure or are inappropriate to the style. - Limited control of rhythm. E.g. the stimulus vocal is out of time with the instrumental parts. - Limited control of harmony detrimental to the music.
Level 2	2	- An attempt at structuring and control of key and modulation but compromised by insecurities and misjudgements. - Some control of chords and chord progressions but compromised by misjudgements. - A serious attempt at writing melodic lines but generally stiff, unstylistic and/or repetitive. - Repetitive rhythms or a surfeit of rhythmic ideas. - Harmony is functional but uninteresting.
Level 3	3	- Generally well managed structuring and control of key and modulation but with some obvious misjudgements and/or missed opportunities. - Generally well managed control of appropriate chords and chord progressions despite some obvious misjudgements and/or limitations. - A good melodic sense. Melodies have shape and style. - Appropriate use of rhythms with some development as appropriate to the style. - Harmony is functional but uninteresting. The same chord set is used throughout.

Level	Mark	Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Coherence (AO2)
Level 4	4	• Well managed structuring and control of key and modulation, but with one or two misjudgements and/or missed opportunities. • Convincing control of appropriate chords and chord progressions despite a few misjudgements. • A strong sense of melodic flow as appropriate to the style. • Excellent stylistic rhythmic elements. • Appropriately chosen harmonies with some variety of chord sets.
Level 5	5	• Effective structuring and control of key and modulation throughout. • Mature and sophisticated control of appropriate chords and chord progressions. • Excellent and imaginative with a strong sense of melodic flow as appropriate to the style. • Excellent and imaginative use of stylistic rhythmic elements. • Imaginative harmony appropriate to the style.

Composition assessment grid 2: Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Expressive Control

Marks are awarded for the control of appropriate and expressive stylistic characteristics, idioms, conventions and procedures appropriate to the brief and for the awareness of occasion and audience, for example, characteristic cadential devices in the Bach chorale, the accurate capture of appropriate dance styles or the handling of the chosen style for the arrangement.

Level	Mark	Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Expressive Control (AO2)
	0	No rewardable material
Level 1	1	• Little evidence of control of style and stylistic procedures. • The style is recognisable but compromised by serious misjudgements. • There is no variety and an over- reliance on looping and repetition.
Level 2	2	• The control of style and stylistic procedures is compromised by some significant misjudgements. • Some inconsistency of style. Stylistic features have been attempted unsuccessfully. • Music is unpredictable or overly repetitive.
Level 3	3	• Some effective control of style and stylistic procedures but with some obvious inconsistencies and/or misjudgements. • Generally a convincing sense of style but with some minor misjudgements. • The structure is functional but uninteresting.
Level 4	4	• Generally convincing control of style and stylistic procedures but with one or two misjudgements. • Most of the features of the style have been included successfully. Musical ideas are presented with a sense of direction and coherence as appropriate to the style with few misjudgements. • The structure is stylistic but some sections may not link well together.
Level 5	5	• Assured control of style and stylistic procedures, applied creatively and expressively. • All features of the style have been included creatively. • The structure is stylistic and sections are well linked.

Composition assessment grid 3: Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Technical Control

Marks are awarded for the handling of techniques appropriate to the brief chosen.

In the Bach chorale and two-part counterpoint, the security of the part writing and handling of dissonance. In the arrangement task, the handling of the instrumentation and textures, and in the remix task, the handling of timbres, sound manipulation and procedures.

Level	Mark	Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Technical Control (AO2)
	0	No rewardable material
Level 1	1	• Little evidence of control of technical procedures and devices • Many misjudgements in the control of part writing and dissonance. • Instrumentation, timbres and sound manipulation lack control with many misjudgements • The style is recognisable but compromised by serious misjudgements. • There is no variety and an over- reliance on looping and repetition.
Level 2	2	• Handling of technical procedures and devices is compromised by technical weaknesses • Part writing and control of dissonance are compromised by some significant errors • Instrumentation, timbres and sound manipulation compromised by misjudgements and limitations • Some inconsistency of style. Stylistic features have been attempted unsuccessfully. • Music is unpredictable or overly repetitive.

Level	Mark	Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Technical Control (AO2)
Level 3	3	• Inconsistent handling of technical procedures and devices • Part writing and control of dissonance are generally successful but with some obvious misjudgements • Instrumentation, timbres and sound manipulation generally successful but with some obvious misjudgements. • Generally a convincing sense of style but with some minor misjudgements. • The structure is functional but uninteresting.
Level 4	4	• Generally secure handling of technical procedures and devices • Part writing and control of dissonance are successful apart from one or two marginal misjudgements • Handling of instrumentation, timbres and sound manipulation is broadly satisfying despite some minor misjudgements • Most of the features of the style have been included successfully. • Musical ideas are presented with a sense of direction and coherence as appropriate to the style with few misjudgements.
Level 5	5	• Distinctive and secure handling of technical procedures and devices throughout • Part writing and control of dissonance successful throughout. • Instrumentation, timbres and sound manipulation handled with assurance • All features of the style have been included creatively. • The structure is stylistic and sections are well linked.

Composition assessment grid 4.1: Response to the brief – Bach Chorale

1. Bach chorale

Marks are awarded for the overall response to the brief in terms of creative response and development of the given stimulus.

Level	Mark	Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Technical Control (AO2)
	0	No rewardable material
Level 1	1	• Little evidence of development of, or a controlled response to, the stimulus • Little evidence of melodic shape.
Level 2	2	• An attempt at developing the stimulus but this is compromised by technical weaknesses. • Lines are often angular and/or lack direction.
Level 3	3	• Response to the stimulus is limited in places by missed opportunities or a formulaic and/or mechanical approach. • Lines lack shape and/or contrast in parts.
Level 4	4	• There is some creativity and fluency in the handling of the stimulus. • Lines are mostly well shaped despite some minor misjudgements.
Level 5	5	• The stimulus is harmonised with fluency and creativity. • Lines are elegant and well shaped.

Composition assessment grid 4.2: Response to the brief – Two-part counterpoint

2. Two-part counterpoint

Marks are awarded for the overall response to the brief in terms of creative response and development of the given stimulus.

Level	Mark	Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Technical Control (A02)
	0	No rewardable material
Level 1	1	• Little evidence of development of, or a controlled response to, the stimulus • Little evidence of melodic shape and/or rhythmic interest.
Level 2	2	• An attempt at developing the stimulus but this is compromised by technical weaknesses. • Lines are often angular and/or lack direction: Rhythm dull and unvaried.
Level 3	3	• The stimulus is developed but limited in places by missed opportunities or a formulaic and/or mechanical approach. • Melodic lines lack shape and/or contrast in parts: rhythmic interest inconsistent and/or lacking variety.
Level 4	4	• There is some development and fluency in the handling of the stimulus. • Lines are mostly well shaped and rhythm creatively handled despite some minor misjudgements.
Level 5	5	• The stimulus is developed with fluency and creativity. • Lines are elegant and well shaped with rhythmic interest.

Composition assessment grid 4.3: Response to the brief – Arrangement

3. Arrangement

Marks are awarded for the overall response to the brief in terms of creative response and development of the given stimulus.

Level	Mark	Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Technical Control (A02)
	0	No rewardable material
Level 1	1	• Little evidence of development of, or a controlled response to, the stimulus
Level 2	2	• There is an attempt at developing the stimulus but this is compromised by technical weaknesses. • Additional material, where added, is unconvincing.
Level 3	3	• The stimulus is developed but limited in places by missed opportunities or a formulaic and/or mechanical approach. • Additional material, where added, is inconsistently handled.
Level 4	4	• There is some development and fluency in the handling of the stimulus. • Additional material is mostly convincing despite some minor misjudgements.
Level 5	5	• The stimulus is developed with fluency and creativity. • Additional material, where appropriate, is convincing and enhances the overall impression.

Composition assessment grid 4.4: Response to the brief – Remix

4. Remix

Marks are awarded for the overall response to the brief in terms of creative response and development of the given stimulus.

Level	Mark	Creating and Developing Musical Ideas with Technical Control (AO2)
	0	No rewardable material
Level 1	1	There are rhythm and/or harmony errors in how the stimulus has been set, or not all of stimulus used.
Level 2	2	Limited use of the stimulus or simple repetition of the given material.
Level 3	3	- However, the audio is cut up and re-arranged to fit a new structure. - The music and stimulus fit but the stimulus audio is largely unaltered.
Level 4	4	- Makes good use of the stimulus material, developing it in a logical but mostly convincing fashion. - The vocal part has been edited to create some new material.
Level 5	5	- Makes imaginative use of the stimulus with extensive and convincing development. - The vocal part has been reconceptualised/edited to create new parts that play simultaneously.

Security and backups

It is the centre's responsibility to ensure that the assignment briefs are kept secure until released to students.

It is also the centre's responsibility to keep the work that students have submitted for assessment secure. Secure storage is defined as a securely-locked cabinet or cupboard.

The rules on storage also apply to electronic data. For example, centres should collect memory sticks for secure storage between sessions or restrict student access to specific areas of the centre's IT network.

For materials stored electronically, centres are strongly advised to utilise firewall protection and virus-checking software, and to employ an effective backup strategy, so that an up-to-date archive of students' evidence is maintained.

Further information

For up-to-date advice on teacher involvement and administration of non-examination assessments, please refer to the Joint Council for Qualifications (JCQ) document *Instructions for conducting non-examination assessments (new GCE and GCSE specifications)* available on the JCQ website: www.jcq.org.uk